

Prose User Guide

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Prose is an operating system for people who write: the Haiku system, built for arm64 and running on your Mac under macOS's Virtualization.framework, with its display drawn by the Mac's own GPU. To the Mac it is one application, **Prose.app**; inside its window is a whole machine, with its own desktop, applications, files, and a folder it shares with the Mac.

Prose running on macOS: the guest desktop in a Prose.app window

This guide is about that application: putting it on a Mac, and driving it once it is there. It covers the menus, the toolbar and the status bar, the keyboard, and the settings. It does not cover the software *inside* the machine — that is the guest's own territory.

What is in this guide

Page	What it covers
Installing Prose	What you need, the installer, updating, and taking it off again.
The Prose Window	The display, the toolbar, the status bar, and the states in between.
The Menus	Every menu item, menu by menu, with its shortcut.
The Keyboard	Who owns which key, and the shortcuts that are the Mac's.
Settings	Processors, memory, networking, sound, and the shared folder.

The shape of the thing

An installation of Prose is more than one file, and the parts have different owners:

- **The application** — Prose.app, ours, always safe to replace.
- **The machine** — one disk image that is the guest's whole computer: its system, its drivers, and everything you have ever put in it. Yours.
- **Your settings** — how big, how loud, what is shared.

- **Your shared folder** — a folder of yours the machine can see. None of our business.

The installer knows the difference. That is the whole reason it exists: drag-and-drop can only ever replace the application, and the one thing it silently cannot do is update the machine — which is how a newer Prose comes to boot an older machine and sit there reporting that its portal will not answer.

A note on names

Prose is not Haiku, and Haiku is not Prose. Prose is an unofficial, experimental port that owes everything to the Haiku project; everything that makes the system inside the window good is their work. Haiku itself — the real thing, and very much worth your time — is at haiku-os.org.

Installing Prose

What you need

- An **Apple Silicon Mac** running **macOS 27 or later**. Prose's display, keyboard and MIDI devices need virtualization features that do not exist before macOS 27.
- About **2 GB of free space**: the application and the machine together.
- Nothing else. The machine's disk image comes inside the installer; there is no separate download and no account.

The installer

Prose arrives as a signed, notarized disk image — a `.dmg` holding exactly one thing, **Installer**. Double-click the disk image, then double-click Installer. There is nothing to dismiss and nothing to drag.

Prose.app travels *inside* the installer, so the disk image has no second item and nobody has to guess whether to drag the application somewhere or open something else. The installer puts each part where it belongs:

<code>/Applications/Prose.app</code>	the application
<code>~/Library/Application Support/Prose/Machines/Prose.image</code>	the machine
<code>~/Documents/HostFS</code>	made by Prose, never touched

The choices

The installer shows each part as its own line, with a checkbox:

Choice	Where it goes	Default
Application	Replaces or installs Prose in Applications.	On
File system	The machine the guest runs, with its drivers and the portal Prose talks to it through, copied into Application Support.	On for a first install
Reset settings	Presenter mode, whether automation is allowed, window and toolbar.	Off

One rule runs through the defaults: **a default never destroys something you made**. If a machine already exists, replacing it is off by default and marked in orange, because replacing it loses everything in it — files, settings, anything you installed. Replacing it is sometimes the right thing (it says so below), but it is your decision, not the installer's.

First run

When the installer finishes it offers **Open Prose**. The first run takes a moment: Prose sets up its folders and starts the machine. You will see the boot splash, then the desktop.

Updating

Run the installer from the new disk image. It reads what is on the Mac and offers the same choices, with the same rule:

- **Application** is ticked by default — replacing it is always safe.
- **File system** is unticked by default when you have a machine. If the installer knows your machine was made by an earlier version of Prose, it says so plainly: the old machine keeps that version's drivers and portal, so automation and other new plumbing may not work until it is replaced. The symptom is Prose reporting that its own portal will not answer. Replacing it still loses everything in it — move files you care about out first (the shared folder, described in [Settings](#), is the easy way), then tick the box.

Your shared folder — `~/Documents/HostFS` by default — is never touched by an install or an update.

Taking it off again

The installer's **Uninstall...** button turns it around, part by part:

Choice	What goes
Application	Prose from Applications, and its logs.
File system	The machine, and everything in it. Shown with its size; asks once more before proceeding.
Settings	The preferences file.
Shared folder	<code>~/Documents/HostFS</code> — your own files. Off by default, and it says how many items would go.

Uninstalling cannot be undone; removing the file system frees its space and that is all that can honestly be said about it.

Building it yourself

Everything is built from source in the project repository, if you would rather make your own:

```
scripts/build-image.sh          # applies the patches, builds the image
tools/build.sh                  # builds Prose.app
private_workspace/run-vz.sh desktop --keep # boots it
```

That path needs Xcode 27 and a case-sensitive volume for the Haiku source tree; the repository's `BUILDING.md` covers it. Everyone else should use the installer.

The Keyboard

While the Prose window is active, **every key goes to Prose**. The machine is a whole computer and the window is its keyboard: ⌘ is Prose's Command key and ⌥ its Option key, so the shortcuts you know from the Mac work inside the machine, on the machine's own terms.

The window's own shortcuts — the ones the Mac side answers to — add Control to Command:

Shortcut	The window's action
⌘F	Enter or leave full screen
⌘P	Pause or resume
⌘R	Restart
⌘S	Screenshot
⌘T	Show or hide the toolbar
⌘/	Show or hide the status bar
⌘0	Actual size
⌘H	Hide Prose
⌘M	Minimize
⌘?	The keyboard summary (Help menu)

There is no ⌘Q by design: that chord belongs to the Mac, and Quit has none — closing the window shuts Prose down anyway.

Keys a Mac keyboard cannot type are in **Machine ▶ Send Keys**: Control-Alt-Delete, which opens the guest's Team Monitor, and Print Screen.

The Menus

One convention covers them all: **the guest owns the keyboard**. While the Prose window is active, ⌘ is Prose's Command key and ⌥ its Option key, so the shortcuts you know inside the machine are the ones it answers to. The window's own shortcuts add Control: they are ⌘ chords, listed with each item below (and collected on [the next page](#)).

The Prose menu

Item	Shortcut	What it does
About Prose		Version, and what the machine is made of: virtual CPUs, memory, display, and where its disk image lives.
Settings...	⌘,	Opens Settings .
Services		The Mac's Services menu.
Hide Prose	⌘H	Hide the window; the machine keeps running.
Hide Others / Show All		The Mac's usual window management.
Quit Prose		Quits, shutting the machine down first. There is deliberately no shortcut — ⌘Q would lock the Mac's screen — and closing the window does the same job.

The Machine menu

Item	Shortcut	What it does
Start		Start the machine when it is off.
Shut Down		Shut Prose down, as if you pressed its power button. Hold ⌥ for Force Stop : off without shutting down, for a machine that will not listen.
Restart	⌘R	Shut Prose down, then start it again. Hold ⌥ for Force Restart .
Pause / Resume	⌘P	Pause the machine, or pick it up where it left off. The title says which.
Send Keys ▾		Keys a Mac keyboard doesn't have: Control-Alt-Delete (the guest's Team Monitor) and Print Screen .
Take Screenshot	⌘S	Save a picture of Prose's screen.
Open Guest Log	⌘L	The machine's own boot and debug log, kept from its memory as it ran.
Allow		Off by default. When on, other applications on this Mac may start and stop this

Automation and Testing		machine, send it keyboard and pointer input, capture its screen, and run commands inside it. macOS asks before each application may do so.
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The Dock menu carries the machine's core controls — Pause, Restart, Shut Down, Start, Take Screenshot — without opening the window.

The View menu

Item	Shortcut	What it does
Show Toolbar	⌘T	Hide or show the toolbar (see The Prose Window).
Customize Toolbar...		Arrange the toolbar's buttons; Prose remembers what you kept.
Show Status Bar	⌘/	Hide or show the status bar. The window grows or shrinks by the bar, so the display keeps its size.
Actual Size	⌘0	One guest pixel per point.
Screen Mode ▸		The guest's resolution, from 1024 × 768 to 3840 × 2160. The window resizes to suit.
Scale ▸		How big one guest pixel is here: 1×, 2× or 4×.
Presenter ▸		Above 1×: Crisp (hard pixels, nothing invented) or Smooth (interpolated edges).
Theme ▸		The machine's themes — a decorator, the system's colours and the wallpaper, kept by the machine itself. Available while it is running.
Host Files in Finder		Reveal the folder the machine mounts as its HostFS volume.
Enter Full Screen	⌘F	The machine takes the whole screen.

The Window menu

Item	Shortcut	What it does
Minimize	⌘M	The Mac's Minimize; the machine keeps running.
Zoom		The Mac's Zoom.
Bring All to Front		The Mac's usual.

The Help menu

Item	Shortcut	What it does
Keyboard Shortcuts	^⌘?	The one-panel summary of who owns which key.

1

Settings

Prose ▶ Settings... (⌘,) is what the machine is made of, and the window for changing it. None of it can change while the machine is running — the virtualization layer fixes a machine's make-up at the moment it is created — so what you change here takes effect the **next time the machine starts**. The window offers **Restart Now** for exactly that.

Setting	What it chooses
Processors	How many virtual CPUs the machine gets. The window stops at the Mac's own core count — handing the guest more than the host has would leave nowhere for macOS to run.
Memory	Gigabytes of memory. The window keeps 8 GB back for the Mac for the same reason.
Networking	The machine's network, on or off. On, it is NAT: the machine has its own address and reaches the world through the Mac.
Sound	The machine's audio, out to (and, when an app asks, in from) the Mac.
Share a folder with the guest	The Mac folder the machine mounts as a volume, with a Read only option.

The shared folder (HostFS)

The shared folder is the two-way bridge: a folder of yours that appears inside Prose as a disk volume, so files move between the Mac and the machine by ordinary dragging. It is `~/Documents/HostFS` unless you choose another, writable unless you say otherwise, and — worth saying twice — **never touched by the installer, an update, or an uninstall** unless you tick the box that says to. **View ▶ Host Files in Finder** reveals it from the Prose window.

Inside the machine the volume is called HostFS and behaves like a local disk, including Haiku attributes, which are kept as extended attributes on the Mac side.

Automation

Machine ▶ Allow Automation and Testing is the one setting that lives in a menu rather than the Settings window, because it is not about the machine — it is about who else on the Mac may drive it. Off by default. When on, other applications on this Mac can start and stop the machine, send it keyboard and pointer input, capture its screen, and run commands inside it; macOS itself asks before each application may do so, through Privacy & Security ▶ Automation. Nothing it offers reaches the Mac beyond the Prose window and the shared folder you chose to give it.

The Prose Window

The Prose window is three things stacked: a toolbar of machine controls across the top, the guest's display filling the window, and a thin status bar along the bottom. Everything the machine does to the window — pausing, shutting down, failing to start — happens inside the display area, as an overlay you can act on.

The display

The display is the guest's screen, live. Drag the window's corner and the guest changes screen mode to follow it — the machine behaves like a monitor that happens to be a window. How sharp that is on your Mac is a pair of settings under **View**:

- **View ▶ Scale** is how big one guest pixel is on your Mac: **1x** is one guest pixel per screen pixel — sharpest, and on a Retina display half the size things appear elsewhere; **2x** and **4x** magnify.
- **View ▶ Presenter** (only meaningful above 1x) chooses what happens to a guest pixel that covers more than one of the Mac's: **Crisp** leaves it a hard block and invents nothing; **Smooth** interpolates, so edges soften instead of stepping.
- **View ▶ Screen Mode** sets the guest's resolution outright, from 1024 × 768 up to 3840 × 2160; the window resizes to suit.

View ▶ Actual Size (^⌘0) returns the display to one guest pixel per point. **View ▶ Enter Full Screen** (^⌘F) gives the machine the whole screen.

The toolbar

The toolbar holds the machine's controls as buttons:

Button	What it does
Start / Shut Down	The power button. It says Start when the machine is off, Shut Down when it is running — and becomes a Stop button once a shutdown is under way, for the one that will not wait.
Pause	Pause the virtual machine. Pausing is instant and resumable; nothing runs while it is paused.
Restart	Shut Prose down, then start it again.
Send Keys	A menu of keys a Mac keyboard doesn't have.
Screenshot	Save a picture of Prose's screen; the flash and the saved-file note in the status bar confirm it.
Full Screen	Show Prose on the whole screen.

Two more buttons are available but not on the default bar: **Force Stop** (turn the machine off without shutting Prose down — the virtual equivalent of holding the power button) and **Status Bar** (show or hide the bar). **View ▶ Customize Toolbar...** arranges all of them; the Mac's usual drag-and-drop applies, and Prose remembers what you kept.

The status bar

A thin strip under the display, in the manner of a machine's front panel.

On the left: the **state light and label** — Starting..., Running, Paused, Shutting down..., Restarting..., Shut down, or Failed to start — beside the **uptime** clock, then the **display mode** (the guest's resolution, with the scale beside it whenever it is not 1x), and room for a passing remark ("Screenshot saved...").

On the right, the machine's activity:

Indicator	Meaning
Processor	The machine's share of the Mac's processors, as a percentage of its virtual CPUs. Hover for memory use.
Disk	Two lights: green reading, orange writing. Hover for the image's name and totals.
Network	The machine's address ("no address" until the lease arrives) and two lights: green receiving, orange sending. Hover for the MAC address and totals.
Sound	Lit while Prose is playing sound.
Microphone	Appears only while Prose is recording from the Mac's sound input.
MIDI	Flashes on MIDI messages from Prose, played by the Mac's synthesizer.

Every indicator has a tooltip with the detail behind its number. **View ▸ Show Status Bar** (^⌘/) hides the bar or brings it back; with a window, the window grows or shrinks by the bar so the guest's display keeps its size.

The states in between

When the machine is not simply running, the display is dimmed under an overlay with the one button that matters:

State	The overlay says	The button
Paused	Paused	Resume
Shut down	Prose is shut down	Start
Failed	The virtual machine stopped, with the reason	Start

Closing the window is the ordinary way to finish: Prose shuts the machine down and quits. The Dock icon carries the machine's controls too — Pause, Restart, Shut Down, Start, Take Screenshot — for when the window is not handy.